



Russia and Kazakhstan

THE RUSSIAN FEDERATION is the biggest country in the world, almost twice as big as either the US or China. It extends halfway around the world, crosses two continents, and spans 11 time zones. The vast region of Siberia alone is larger than Canada. Kazakhstan lies to its south and is a large but sparsely populated country. From 1917 to 1991, both countries were part of the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR), the world's first communist state. When the USSR collapsed, Russia, Kazakhstan, and the 13 other member republics gained independence. Today, Russia and Kazakhstan are both ruled by elected presidents. Both countries have a lot of fertile land, huge mineral deposits, and many other natural resources. However, Russia still has a very low life expectancy rate compared to other industrialized countries.

Lake Baikal is up to 6,365 ft (1,940 m) deep and contains more than 20 percent of the world's freshwater supply.

Kazakh man hunting with a trained golden eagle

KAZAKH CULTURE

The majority of people in Kazakhstan are Kazakh Muslims. They were once a nomadic people who traveled around on horseback, herding their sheep. Although about half of the Kazakhs live in rural areas, retaining a strong loyalty to their clans and families, the city of Almaty and the new, modern capital of Astana are growing quickly, due to wealth generated by oil and gas.

Coal miners in Siberia



NATURAL WEALTH

Siberia contains around a quarter of the world's natural gas reserves and has vast deposits of oil, as well as abundant minerals such as coal and precious metals including gold. However, many of these resources are inaccessible or in remote places, and the extreme winters make it difficult to extract them.

